leaders—few of whom are generally identified with Hindu nationalism—as early pathfinders of Hindutva. 'It is the same Hindutva, not necessarily Hindu society, about which Vivekananda, Subhas Chandra Bose, Gurudev Rabindranath Thakur, Dr Babasaheb Ambedkar, etc. have spoken about,' he said. 'The expression of those values depends on the person and the situation.'[21]

Hindutva, for the RSS, extends to the pre-historic past, when even the word 'Hindu' had not been invented. It encompasses the ancient epics and their gods, including Ram and Krishna. From the heroes in those epics to medieval rulers like Maharana Pratap and Shivaji, who fought the Mughals, the RSS sees an unbroken chain of Hindutva. 'There was no word called "Hindu" at the time of Maryada Purushottam Shri Ram, but He is still an icon of Hindutva,' Bhagwat asserted. 'The principles that He practised were considered to be ideal and they are later called Hindutva. On the other hand, Sri Krishna, who in a way broke all the norms of propriety of conduct but still He was following Hindutva. The same is true about Parshuram, who used violence and Karunavatar Buddha who practised and preached non-violence. All of them, gave expression to Hindutva as per the need of the then society. Shivaji Maharaj extended respect to Mirza Raja. He was also following the Hindutva.'[22]

Bhagwat disagreed that there were multiple ways of being Hindu that differed from Hindutva. For example, he explained, there was no difference between his understanding of Hindutva vis-à-vis the polytheism of Gandhi or the brilliant exposition of a thinker like Swami Vivekanand, who wowed the 1893 Parliament of the World's Religions in Chicago with his characterisation of Hinduism as a tolerant faith of 'universal acceptance' which accepted 'all religions as true'.[23] As Bhagwat put it:[24]

… Hindutva is one. It cannot be different even if one looks at it with different prisms. I believe in Truth and non-violence, but if somebody is attacking me, indirectly to kill the Truth and non-violence I believe in, then to protect those values I will have to fight. Whether to fight or not is not Hindutva, to live or to die for Truth is and non-violence is Hindutva. To fight for a practice of Truth and non-violence is Hindutva. When to suffer and when one should not, can be an